

Flight Dispatcher Interview Preparation Guide

Based on training materials in *random content* folder (main branch)

Target profile: candidate with approximately 1 year of experience

Purpose

This guide summarizes the key operational tasks a flight dispatcher is expected to perform and highlights what to emphasize during interviews for an entry-level/early-career dispatcher role.

Source set includes: flight planning, ATS flight plan filing, RVSM/PBN navigation, takeoff and landing performance, drift-down/depressurization planning, OMA/MEL compliance, emergency response, and dispatch tools (OPT/Flysmart/FPM).

A. Dispatcher Task Synopsis (Role-Based)

1) Pre-flight operational control and flight plan preparation

Collect and validate data (aircraft status, weather, NOTAMs, payload, route restrictions) before building the OFP. Ensure the plan is safe, legal, and economical in line with authority and company manuals.

2) OFP quality checks before release

Verify route logic, fuel policy, alternates, minima, MEL/CDL constraints, EDTO implications, and any non-standard conditions. Reconcile missing interface data with source systems before release.

3) ATS flight plan filing and accuracy control

File an ATS flight plan for each flight based on OFP data and confirm successful transmission. Ensure ICAO items (aircraft ID, equipment, route, EET, alternates, remarks, endurance/POB) are complete and accurate.

4) Airport minima and regulatory compliance

Apply origin/destination/alternate minima using OMA and authority requirements. Cross-check state minima, aircraft capability, and crew qualification constraints.

5) Navigation and airspace compliance (RVSM/PBN/RNAV/RNP)

Confirm aircraft and route suitability for required navigation specifications and RVSM operations. Support efficient and compliant routing while preserving separation and safety margins.

6) Takeoff and landing performance support

Assess runway condition impacts (dry/wet/contaminated), obstacle limitations, climb gradients, brake/tire constraints, and thrust strategy. Confirm performance calculations are valid for operational release.

7) Fuel planning and tankering decisions

Apply fuel policies, evaluate tankering opportunities, and balance economics with safety/performance limits. Protect reserve requirements and alternate/diversion scenarios.

8) En-route contingency planning (engine failure/pressurization/EDTO)

Prepare drift-down and depressurization considerations, diversion strategy, terrain clearance, and speed/fuel trade-offs. Ensure practical options exist for en-route abnormal scenarios.

9) MEL/CDL operational assessment

Interpret dispatch conditions from MEL entries and ATA-based MEL items. Determine if dispatch is allowed, restricted, or prohibited, and communicate operational implications to flight crew/operations control.

10) Operational systems and tool usage

Use dispatch platforms and performance tools (FPM/mfs2, OPT, Flysmart) to build and verify dispatch outputs. Maintain data discipline, version awareness, and clear handover documentation.

11) Shift coordination, communication, and handover

Log key actions, monitor delays/disruptions, and execute structured handover. Coordinate with OCC, crew, ATC messaging channels, and downstream stakeholders.

12) Emergency and business continuity response

In accidents/incidents, preserve records, provide briefing packages, support emergency leadership, and maintain continuity from alternate facilities when required.

B. High-Impact Highlights to Emphasize in Interview

- “Safety first, legality always, efficiency where possible” decision mindset.
- Strong checking discipline before OFP release (weather, NOTAMs, minima, fuel, alternates, MEL impact).
- Clear understanding that dispatch is a shared operational control function, not only paperwork.
- Comfort with ICAO ATS flight plan structure and filing validation steps.
- Practical awareness of abnormal planning: engine-out drift-down, depressurization, and diversion logic.
- Ability to use dispatch/performance software accurately and escalate anomalies early.
- Calm communication under pressure, especially during disruptions or emergency response activation.
- Good record-keeping habits and structured shift handover behavior.

C. Probable Interview Questions with Sample Answers

1) What are your main responsibilities as a flight dispatcher before departure?

I gather and verify operational data, prepare and validate the OFP, ensure regulatory/manual compliance, file ATS flight plans, and coordinate with operations and crew so the flight can be released safely and legally.

2) How do you decide if a flight plan is safe and legal?

I use a checklist approach: weather and NOTAM review, route and alternate suitability, fuel policy compliance, minima checks, MEL/CDL impact, and aircraft performance limits. I only release when all constraints are satisfied.

3) What is the purpose of an ATS flight plan?

It enables ATC handling and alerting services and ensures the flight is correctly represented in the ATM system. It must accurately reflect OFP data and ICAO format requirements.

4) How would you handle missing or inconsistent data in the flight planning system?

I do not assume. I cross-check with source systems and operational stakeholders, correct the data, document what was changed, and re-validate the plan before release.

5) Explain the difference between RNAV and RNP in simple terms.

RNAV allows area navigation between waypoints; RNP includes onboard performance monitoring and alerting. RNP therefore adds assurance that the navigation performance requirement is continuously being met.

6) What changes when the runway is contaminated?

Takeoff and landing performance margins reduce, stopping/climb considerations become stricter, and configuration/thrust choices may change. I ensure the performance output reflects actual runway condition and limits.

7) How do MEL items affect dispatch decisions?

I match aircraft defects to MEL conditions, determine whether dispatch is allowed, and apply required restrictions or procedures. If conditions are not met, dispatch is not allowed.

8) What is your role during an incident or emergency?

I preserve and provide dispatch records promptly, support the emergency response chain with accurate operational data, keep event logs, and continue controlled communication with the command structure.

9) How do you balance safety and commercial pressure?

Safety and compliance are non-negotiable. I look for efficient options only within approved limits and document my rationale for operational decisions.

10) Why are you ready for this role with one year of experience?

In my first year I focused on disciplined planning fundamentals, regulatory awareness, system proficiency, and escalation judgment. I am reliable on routine flights and careful during non-routine situations.

11) How do you perform a good shift handover?

I provide concise status of active flights, pending risks, unresolved technical items, weather/NOTAM watch points, and actions already taken so continuity is maintained without ambiguity.

12) What would you do if weather at destination deteriorates close to departure?

I reassess destination and alternate minima, fuel adequacy, and operational options. I coordinate with OCC/crew, update the plan if needed, and ensure release remains compliant before departure.

D. 30-Second Interview Positioning Statement

"I approach dispatch as operational risk management. My focus is to release flights that are safe, legal, and practical by checking data quality, route/fuel logic, minima, and aircraft status thoroughly. With one year of experience, I bring strong planning discipline, tool proficiency, and calm coordination during both routine and disrupted operations."